

companies, drug manufacturers and marketers, and health maintenance organizations (HMOs).

Hammers and Nails

In all, professional relationships with clients have been increasingly recast as business relationships with customers. In a world where every user of services is seen as a customer, every provider of services becomes a seller. Put another way, when the provider becomes a hammer, the customer is seen as a nail. Please don't think me naive. I'm fully aware that every profession has elements of a business. Indeed, if revenues fail to exceed expenses, no organization—even the most noble of faith-based institutions—will long exist. But as so many of our nation's proudest professions gradually shift their traditional balance away from that of trusted professions serving the interests of their clients of the community and toward that of commercial enterprises seeking competitive advantage, the human beings who rely on those services are the losers.

A few years ago, the author Roger Lowenstein made a similar observation, bemoaning the loss of the “Calvinist rectitude” that had its roots in “the very Old World notions of integrity, ethics, and unyielding loyalty to the customer.” “America's professions,” he wrote, “have become crassly commercial . . . with accounting firms sponsoring golf tournaments,” and, he might have added, mutual fund managers not only doing the same thing but buying naming rights to stadiums as well.^{[16](#)} “The battle for [professional] independence,” he concluded, “is never won.”

Capitalism Changes Its Values

Our commercial enterprises, too, have moved a long way from the traditional values of capitalism. The origins of modern capitalism, beginning with the industrial revolution in Great Britain back in the